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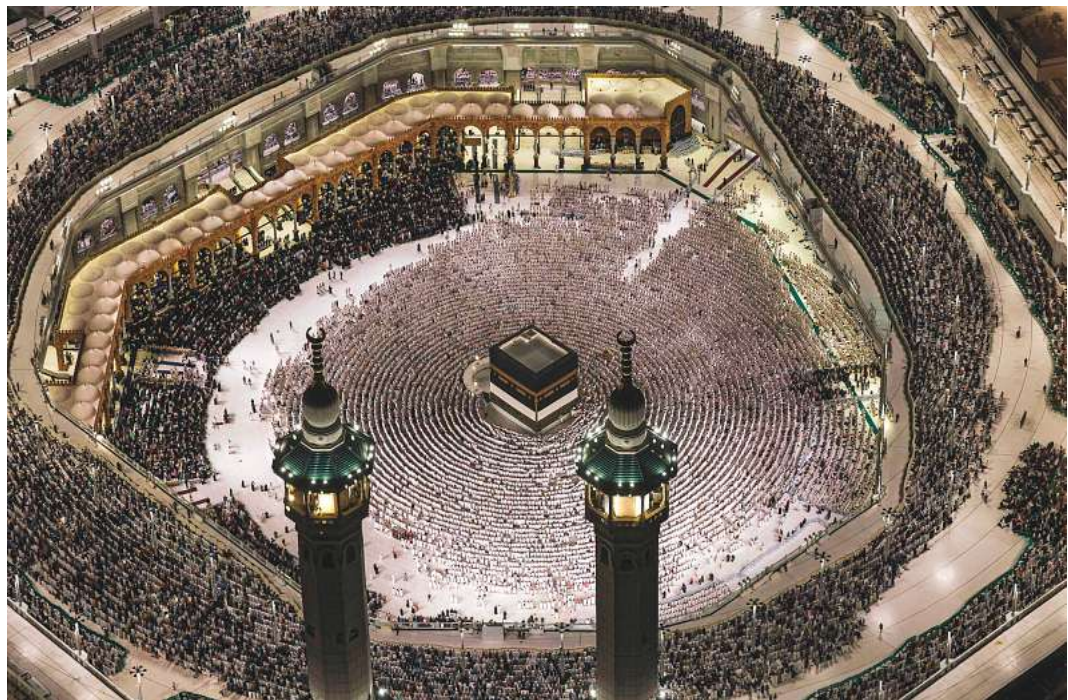
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AFP

■ Worshippers gather to pray around the Kaaba at the Grand Mosque complex in Makkah on Sunday ahead of the annual Haj pilgrimage.

1.5 million pilgrims arrive in Makkah ahead of annual Haj

Authorities assure safe pilgrimage amid searing desert heat

MAKKAH

More than a million pilgrims poured into Makkah ahead of the annual Haj, with authorities vowing to hold a safer pilgrimage amid searing desert heat and a massive crackdown on illegal visitors.

Officials have beefed up heat mitigation measures hoping to avoid a repeat of last year's Haj, which saw 1,301 pilgrims die as temperatures reached 51.8 degrees Celsius (125.2 Fahrenheit).

Temperatures were forecast to exceed 40 degrees Celsius this week as one of the world's largest annual religious gatherings starts tomorrow.

The Haj, one of the five pillars of Islam, must be performed at least once by all Muslims with the means.

As of yesterday, nearly 1.5 million pilgrims had arrived in Saudi Arabia for the multi-day pilgrimage, according to officials.

This year, authorities have mobilised more than 40 government agencies and 250,000

400

cooling units will be deployed for pilgrims

officials, doubling their efforts against heat-related illness following the lethal heatwave of 2024.

Shaded areas have been expanded by 50,000 square metres (12 acres), thousands more medics will be on standby, and more than 400 cooling units will be deployed, Saudi Arabia's Haj minister Tawfiq Al Rabiah told AFP last week.

Yesterday, with temperatures topping 40 degrees Celsius, the health ministry said 44 cases of heatstroke had already been treated.

AI tech

The latest artificial intelligence technology will also help monitor the flood of data and footage, including video from a new fleet of drones, from across Makkah to better manage the mammoth crowds.

Despite the punishing heat, pilgrims were overjoyed as they arrived in Makkah.

"This is really a blessing from Allah," Abdul Majid Ati, a Filipino lawyer and Sharia counsellor, told AFP near the Grand Mosque. "We feel so peaceful and safe in this place."

Abdul Hamid, from Nigeria, said he was "very happy" to be performing his second pilgrimage in a row at just 27 years old.

But the young man said he never walks out without his sunglasses, describing the temperatures in Makkah as "very, very, very hot".

The rites in the holy city and its surroundings, which follow a lunar calendar, fall again this year during the hot month of June.

Last year, most of the deaths were among unregistered pilgrims who lacked access to air-conditioned tents and buses.

"They were caught by surprise because the intensity of the heat was so high that their adaptation measures failed," said Fahad Saeed of Climate Analytics, a think tank based in Germany.

In the run-up to this year's Haj, Saudi authorities launched a widespread crackdown on unregistered worshippers, using frequent raids, drone surveillance and a barrage of text alerts.

— AFP

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How AI 'factcheckers' like Grok sow misinformation

India-Pakistan conflict a prime example

WASHINGTON

As misinformation exploded during India's four-day conflict with Pakistan, social media users turned to an AI chatbot for verification — only to encounter more falsehoods, underscoring its unreliability as a fact-checking tool.

"Hey @Grok, is this true?" has become a common query on Elon Musk's platform X, where the AI assistant is built in.

But the responses are often themselves riddled with misinformation.

Grok wrongly identified old video footage from Su-

dan's Khartoum airport as a missile strike on Pakistan's Nur Khan airbase during the country's recent conflict with India.

Not reliable

Unrelated footage of a building on fire in Nepal was misidentified as "likely" showing Pakistan's military response to Indian strikes.

"Our research has found that AI chatbots are not reliable sources for news and information, particularly when it comes to breaking news," McKenzie Sadeghi, a researcher with the disinformation watchdog NewsGuard, said.

— AFP

Russia rejects unconditional Ukraine truce

MOSCOW PROPOSES A PARTIAL CEASEFIRE OF 'TWO TO THREE DAYS'

ISTANBUL

Russia rejected an unconditional ceasefire with Ukraine at peace negotiations between the two sides held in Istanbul yesterday, a Kyiv negotiator, Sergiy Kyslytsya, said.

"The Russian side continued to reject the motion of an unconditional ceasefire," Kyslytsya told reporters in a press conference after the talks.

Ukraine proposed to hold a next round of talks with Russia before the end of June.

Russia on its part proposed a partial ceasefire of "two to three days", Moscow's top negotiator Vladimir Medinsky said.

"We have proposed a specific ceasefire for two to three days in certain areas of the front line," Medinsky said, "so that commanders can collect the bodies of their soldiers."

Prisoners' exchange

The two sides have agreed to exchange prisoners of war who are severely wounded as well as those under the age of 25, and also the remains of 6,000 killed soldiers, Kyiv said.

"We agreed to exchange all-for-all seriously wounded and seriously sick prisoners of war. The second category is young soldiers who are from 18 to 25 years old — all-for-all. Also we agreed to return 6,000 to 6,000 bodies of fallen soldiers,"

Urged on by US President Donald Trump, Moscow and Kyiv have opened direct negotiations for the first time since the early weeks of Russia's invasion, but have yet to make significant progress towards an elusive agreement.

Ukraine's lead negotiator and Defence Minister Rustem Umerov told reporters in Istanbul.

Urged on by US President Donald Trump, Moscow and Kyiv have opened direct negotiations for the first time since the early weeks of Russia's invasion, but have yet to make significant progress towards an elusive agreement.

Yesterday's talks came a day after Ukraine carried out one of its most brazen and successful attacks ever on Russian soil — hitting dozens of strategic bombers parked at airbases thousands of kilometres behind the front line.

A first round of talks in Istanbul last month yielded a large-scale prisoner exchange but no pause in the fighting, which has raged since Russia invaded in February 2022. Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan mediated this round of talks. — Agencies

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